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EDITOR'S NOTE

“When you teach a man to hate and fear his brother, then you also learn to confront others not as fellow citizens but as enemies” - Robert F. Kennedy

“We can make an effort, as Martin Luther King did, to understand and to comprehend, and to replace that violence, that stain of bloodshed that has spread across our land, with an effort to understand with compassion and love.” Robert F. Kennedy

From Centre St to Pennsylvania Avenue: A Lesson on Political Violence From Robert Kennedy

By the PRISM Editor-in-Cheifs

Though the busy newscycle of 2026 has eroded discussion within the American populace, the assassination of Charlie Kirk was truly one of the most significant moments in recent American politics. Kirk was a pillar of the Republican Party, organizing and publicizing the Conservative Movement. Kirk had not attended college, viewing it to have strayed too far to the left, and self educated himself. What brought him to notoriety, however, was his famous campus tours; he would travel to college campuses and set up a table with a sign reading “ask me anything.” This method was contrasted with the modern media system, a system in which publications both on the right and left attempt to control narratives, increase polarity, and profit from shocking clips. Kirk, at a campus event on September 10th 2025, was assassinated in front of a crowd of college students at Utah Valley University. The PRISM Youth Journal takes the unwavering stance that this action, and all political violence, cannot exist in any form in our republic. It is crucial that as a nation we learn from our history, and do not slide down the slippery slope of political violence.

While this issue of political violence may seem removed from the average American, and to be a problem of our distant past, it touches many lives, and its ripples have been felt by all Americans. It has even touched the Milton Academy community this publication is based out of. Former Attorney General and Presidential Candidate Robert F. Kennedy (Milton Academy Class of 1948), spent his high school days on Centre Street as a notoriously non-conforming individual. Kennedy spent his former days at many institutions, deciding to transfer to Milton from St. Paul's school. His Father, Ambassador Joseph Kennedy, recommended Milton as a strong institution for encouraging freedom of thought,

and most importantly, being one of the primary Harvard feeder schools in the nation. Being a Kennedy meant attending Harvard, and Joe decided Bobby was destined to continue that legacy. Upon arriving at Centre St, Kennedy was noted as having a non-conforming nature. He entered Milton in Class II, and mostly kept to himself in his first months. David Hackett (Class of 1949), Kennedy's best friend and Milton Football teammate, recalled in an oral interview that Kennedy was a "misfit" as he was a Catholic attending a homogeneously Protestant school. His distinguishing characteristic, Hackett recalled, was his "determination." Sam Adams, another peer of Kennedy at Milton, recalled that at football tryouts "[Bobby Kennedy] tore into tackling dummies as if his life depended on it." In addition to his determination and grit, It seems that Kennedy took the school's motto to heart. He sought to be himself, and to allow himself to have the intellectual boldness to remain outwardly Catholic in a homogeneous Protestant institution. Hackett recalled that Kennedy disliked bullying, and would step in when upperclassmen would bully underclassmen. By his senior year, Bobby Kennedy had been permitted by his father to defend his country through enlisting in the military, in no small part because of the selflessness he had developed at Milton. In his biography *Robert Kennedy: His Life*, Evan Thomas writes that at Milton, Kennedy realized his privilege, and began to "notice inequality in the wider world...[and developed a clear] social conscience." This takeaway would be the main lesson Kennedy would learn at Milton, and would pave the way for his devotion to social justice.

Robert Kennedy, the politician, followed in the footsteps of Bobby Kennedy the Milton Academy senior. Kennedy viciously prosecuted the Mob, corrupt union leaders, and Communists within his tenure on the McClellan Committee (1957-1959) and as Attorney General (1961-1964). He approached these prosecutions with the same determination and moralism that he had developed playing football and fighting bullies. Kennedy's moralism was a defining attribute of his time in public life. When his brother, President John F Kennedy was assassinated, RFK became deeply pained. He was described as having "survivor guilt" wishing that he rather than his brother has been killed. Kennedy began, at the suggestion of former first lady Jacqueline Kennedy, reading Greek dramatists and poets. One of RFK's favorite quotes was from Aeschylus' *Agamemnon*: "He who learns must suffer. And even in our sleep pain that cannot forget, falls drop by drop upon the heart, and in our own despair, against our will, comes wisdom to us by the awful grace of God." Kennedy would reuse the quote on April 4th 1968, upon hearing the news of the assassination of Martin Luther King Jr.

RFK's friend Ronald Steel described that "Grief helped humanize [Kennedy]...It even made him more tolerant." Kennedy would announce the death of MLK to a crowd in Indianapolis, Indiana on April 4th 1968 in an improvised speech. He told the crowd that, rather than seeking revenge, violence, and increasing polarity, that "we" should "make an effort, as Martin Luther King did, to understand and to comprehend [others], and to replace that violence, that stain of bloodshed that has spread across our land, with an effort to understand with compassion and love." This quote may be the best summation of what made Robert Kennedy such an important politician. Rather than capitalizing on and encouraging polarization, Kennedy encourages Americans to face violence with love, and to replace hatred with compassion. Soon after, Kennedy would face the bullets of Sirhan Sirhan at a rally in California on account of his support of Israel, and die, having preached for nonviolence, unity, and love till his last breath.

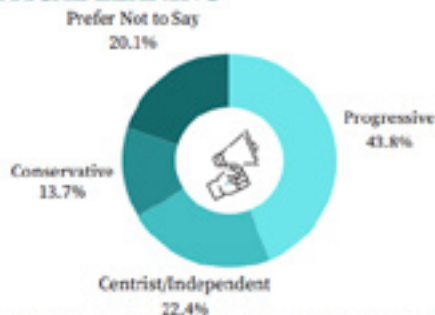
Robert Kennedy was killed for his beliefs. He would not live to see whether his message of love and unity, and his condemnation of polarization, would be achieved. Sadly, it proved to not be adopted by America. The media and President Nixon would soon go to war with one another, and the Watergate scandal would oust the President. As Nixon departed in shame, so too did the hope of a nonpolar America. Kennedy's lesson, however, is of immense importance today. After the death of Charlie Kirk, an alarming trend of people justifying his death was seen. Many people took to social media and news channels justifying the assassination as being the logical conclusion to loudly expressing right wing politics. Sentiments such as 'he had it coming talking like that' and 'he had the wrong politics' were shockingly prevalent. While Kirk may have had political views that the left would find disgusting, this is not grounds for assassination. Those on the left must follow Kennedy and look to counter those views with love and compassion, not follow Serhan and utilize bullets. A nation divided cannot stand. Our American experiment is predicated upon the first amendment, and the freedom for Americans to voice their opinions without fear of imprisonment or death. The loss of human life for political opinions is never justified.

Every Milton Academy student is familiar with our beautiful motto: Dare to Be True. This motto argues that students should dare -they should courageously take the risk to be intellectually honest and curious. Milton students, however, seem to view politics as falling outside of this dare. We approach politics as a cliché; it is implicitly assumed that people will follow the status quo, and deviation implies that that person has a problem. There is little effort to curiously and honestly listen to arguments from across political lines, and little effort to voice unpopular political opinions. The Milton Paper has an an-

nual issue titled The State of the Academy in which data concerning questions relating to a variety of topics asked anonymously to Milton students is compiled. Among that data is questions regarding political leaning. This PRISM editorial will reference the 2024 State of the Academy, as it occurred during an election year, in which politics was within the public consciousness at a higher rate. The Milton Paper found that 20.1% of Milton Students Prefer not to list their political leaning in anonymous polling. Personal politics are such a cliché that even when anonymous, 1:5 students will abstain from revealing their political leanings. The data also showed that among “female respondents [7% identified] as conservative.” Among male respondents, this number was 23%. Nearly 1:4 men at Milton Academy were self-reportedly conservative. Among these conservatives, 91% have felt “the need to censor [themselves] at Milton due to [their] political leaning.” This number is saddening, and a worrying sign that political polarization is infecting our institution. As a school with the motto Dare to be True, we have a responsibility to encourage students to think and associate freely -under the assumption that they will not harm other students. Milton has an incredibly intelligent student body with incredibly interesting minds, and it is the duty of those people to dare to voice their opinions, and to curiously, respectfully, and honestly engage with people who hold differing views. It is the duty of our institution as a whole to enable an environment in which censorship is not widespread -an environment in which those students are embraced with the love Robert Kennedy encouraged. Kennedy served alongside many Republicans in his brother’s administration, and under republican senator Joseph McCarthy. Kennedy, though he disagreed with many of the ideas of the right, sought to treat them with respect and dignity -with love. For Kennedy understood, as Abraham Lincoln dictated, that a house divided could not stand, and that only love can attempt to fix that division. He understood that the cracks in that house’s foundation would only be amplified by revenge and censorship, and sought to achieve political stability through nonviolence and compassion. As a nation, and as members of Milton Academy, we must seek to glue the foundation of our republic through the condemnation of political polarization, revenge, vilification, censorship, and most importantly, violence of all kinds.

POLITICS

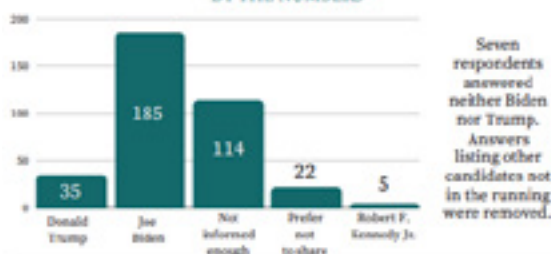
POLITICAL LEANING



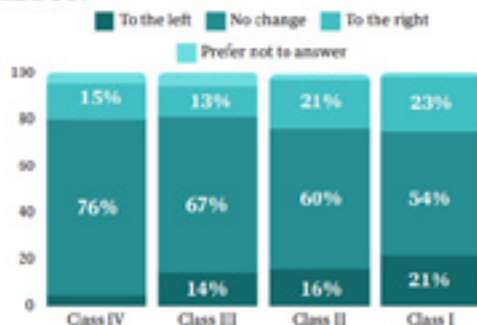
Less than 50% of respondents identified as liberal. 20.1% of respondents chose not to share their political stance. More female respondents identified as progressive with 56% reporting as so, 18% as centrist, and 7% as conservative. The responses for males were more evenly distributed with 31% of males identifying a progressive, 29% as centrist, and 23% as conservative.

PREFERRED PRESIDENTIAL CANDIDATE

BY THE NUMBERS*



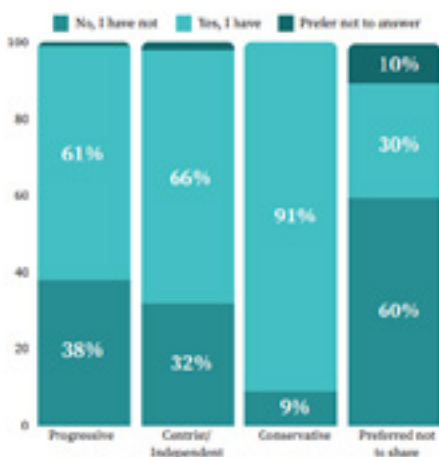
CHANGE IN POLITICAL LEANING AT MILTON



Generally, respondents were more likely to experience some kind of change in political leaning as they progressed through Milton.

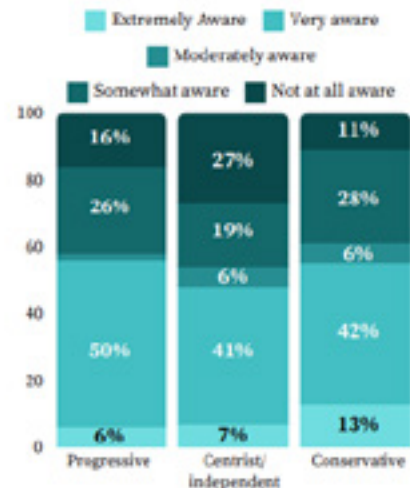
POLITICAL CENSORSHIP

While at Milton, have you ever felt the need to censor yourself due to your political leaning?



SELF-PERCEIVED POLITICAL AWARENESS

Over 70% of respondents of each political ideology reported some self-perceived level of awareness of current events.



Data Courtesy of *The 2024 State of the Academy* by *The Milton Paper*

THE DESTRUCTIVE AND REGRESSIVE NATURE OF MARXISM

HENRY MANNINO

Milton Academy '26

An Introductory Background

4

Bloodshed and volatility are apt descriptors of 19th-20th century Europe. The volatile political unrest of the 1800s led to a wave of newfound political ideologies: namely, that of Marxism in 1848. The case of Marxism seeks to respond to volatility and suffering through repression and social destruction. Karl Marx, having had a falling out with religion, and a philosophical intrigue in the devil, had a predisposition to destruction. Ultimately, his ideas grew to influence the Bolshevik Revolution, and were re-interpreted by Lenin; however, the primary doctrine of Marxism -destruction and repression- remains integral. In the case of the Soviet Union, the world's first structured Communist nation, which emerged from the Russian Revolution, authoritarianism walked hand in hand with Marxist-Leninism. Both Lenin and later Stalin build off of Marxism, and their ideologies become highly reversionary. What is perplexing to many about Stalinism is that some believe it contradicts the desires of Marxist-Leninism. However, Stalinism simply builds off of Marxism and Leninism, and takes the destructive and repressive tendencies to an extreme as a means to consolidate power. All three ideologies prove to be inherently destructive and regressive. Importantly, modern age progressives must understand this as the influx of modern Marxist Progressives and Leninist apologists is detrimental to the progressive goals of many on the left.

Understanding Marx's Pre-Manifesto Ideology

Karl Marx created the first glimpse of the Communist vision, and built it to be inherently regressive and destructive. While a more modern view of Marx places him as forward thinking and bringing about inherent good, More classical historians viewed Marx quite differently. In his time at University of Bonn (1836) studying under Bruno Bauer, Marx solidified his disenchantment with religion, and became enchanted with an atheistic admiration of the devil. His theological ideology is incredibly nuanced as his poetry often

evoked a Miltonian Satan which Marx would write from the perspective of. In his poem *Invocation of One in Despair* (written 1836-1837), Marx writes “I wish to avenge myself against the One who rules above” in a soliloquy speaking on the despotic nature of God from the lips of a prelapsarian post heavenly revolt Satan. This line is seemingly inspired off of the soliloquy of Satan in Book 4 of *Paradise Lost*, and most definitely illustrates a predisposition towards destruction -the same purpose it serves in John Milton’s poem. Marx found the world inherently cruel, though he was an atheist, so his writing against a despotic God seemed perplexing. Well, Marx may be referring to the general world when he writes against God. First of all, Marx was born in Trier, Germany. Trier is a heavily Christian town formerly home to St Helena, home to Emperor Constantine during his Christian conversion, and home to the supposed robes Christ wore during his crucifixion. To Marx, the world is subject to the Judeo-Christian God’s influence, and so when he speaks against God, he is really speaking against society. This may seem to be a slight overreach; however, Marx builds dramatically upon this initial Satanic destructive philosophy.

Particularly, Marx took a liking to Johann Wolfgang von Goethe’s Mephistopheles -a character of German Folklore who symbolizes the devil. It is said that Marx had a particular affection for the character of Mephistopheles, especially Mephistopheles’ quote from *Faust*: “Everything that exists deserves to perish” which some have even prescribed as Marx’s favorite quote in all of literature., This fact is unanimously viewed as important across the ideological spectrum -left wing scholars such as Robert Payne as well as conservative scholars such as Dr Jordan B. Peterson both view this line as critical to Marxist philosophy. Mephistopheles views existence as always leading to suffering, and thereby views existence to be inherently malicious and painful. Through this view of existence, Mephistopheles views civilization as in need of being destroyed as a whole. Marx definitely was influenced heavily by *Faust*. His Father, Hienrich Marx, even asks him in a letter written just seven months after Marx finishes writing “*Invocation of One In Despair*” “...since [your] heart is obviously animated and governed by a demon not granted to all men, is that demon heavenly or Faustian?” (1837) While this could be viewed as a playful joke towards his son, Hienrich writes the letter out of genuine constant worry for his son. Additionally, the view of Marx as being a demon is not uncommon in Marx’s colleagues, so his father being genuinely concerned about him in this regard would not be abnormal. Marx’s son addressed him in a letter as “my dear devil” his colleague Karl Heinzen referred to him as a “wet Goblin...chanting words from faust,” and Fredrich Engeles described him as a dark man from Trier who is the “monster of 10,000 devils” after the two first met. It seems as

though Marx had been consumed by the faustian demon -not necessarily in a theological literal sense, but definitely ideologically- and his faustian devilishness was so deep that it could be viewed upon first notice by strangers and also noticed by his close family. This makes a lot of sense in the context of his future writings. The faustian vision directly builds upon the ideology established in his poetry. Contrary to what his early life alludes to, the literal existence of God is actually not important to Marxist ideology at all. The world is destructive in the eyes of Marx, and the existence of a being who created it is irrelevant. Due to the evil of current existence, everything currently existing must be destroyed, and Marx must be the catalyst.

The Communist Manifesto

6 In the Communist Manifesto (1848), Marx truly hones the Faustian demonic muse and wrote a social regressive and inherently destructive ideological manifesto. Marx began the Manifesto by stating that the “spectre of Communism” is “Haunting Europe” and will eventually be “exorcise[ed].” This places Marxism to be similar to a ghastly warning -the archetypal calm before the storm. It places the Communist revolution as inevitable, as this demon will be exorcised eventually, and as the threat is supernatural -therbye, the threat is also above the paygrade of man. Marx argues at the end of the text that a utopian vision can only be achieved through the “...forcible overthrow of all existing social conditions.” This idea is the threat. It is the direct continuation of his demonic poetry, and Marx argues it is inevitable. Many argue that Communism is forward thinking as it looks to reinterpret society -society which is deemed to cause suffering to the proletariats. However, in reality, it is inherently backwards and regressive as it seeks to destroy everything until no semblance of the past exists. This may abolish some suffering, but it will also abolish all goodness, all current knowledge, and -most importantly- it will abolish all of the progress -medically, scholarly, metaphysically, socially, ect- which currently exists. Furthermore, In arguing for a ‘forcible overthrow’ not even a democratically consented destructive refiguring will take place, but an involuntary holistic destruction. The ideology is the most radical possible political movement, and it is the antithesis of the wave of progress and need for democratic consent considered forward thinking since the enlightenment. Mephistopheles also seeks for destruction of all that exists -in his case all that is created under God- to end supposed suffering. The philosophical issue which Goethe presents is that to end existence, more suffering will arise. Marx’s ideology also falls victim to this. Inherently, to end all of current society, suffering will take place. Marx attempts to mask this contradiction by phrasing

the onslaught of destruction not as a deletion of progress, but as an opportunity for the proletarians to “lose their chains” as they have nothing else to lose. This shifts to focus on a potential end of current suffering, not the plentiful new suffering which will come. This is actually very reminiscent of not strictly Mephistopheles, but also Marx’s early poem *The Fiddler* (Published in ‘Wild Songs’ 1841) where a musician sells his soul to the devil -the archetypal meeting at the Faust inspired crossroads- to be talented at his instrument, and while he achieves that skill, he does it at the cost of the rest of the joy in his life. Ultimately, to achieve the Marxist vision, a crossroads like deal must be made where all of civilization must be sacrificed, and an incredible increase to suffering is inevitable in this sacrifice.

The Revision of Marxism (Marxist-Leninism)

The political situation prior to the Russian Revolution was able to be molded by Vladimir Lenin into a redefinition of Marx’s hypothesized workers revolution, molding it to center not on workers against the factory owners, but to center on peasants against the bourgeoisie - this ideology is now known as Marxist-Leninism. It seems as though Leninism is separated enough from Marxism that it could be described as revisionist, and thereby not adhering to many of Marxism’s core principles. The Leninists tried hard to reckon with this, as Marx was a beloved character, and so through not adhering to his doctrine, one would quickly lose support and be viewed as anti-revolutionary. Joseph Stalin, the People’s Commissariat of Nationalities of the USSR under Lenin, described Leninism as the “Marxism of the era of imperialism and the proletarian revolution. To be more exact, Leninism is the theory and tactics of the proletarian revolution in general.” Whilst Stalin prefaces this statement as proof of Leninism not being revisionist, it actually supports the revisionist point very nicely. First of all, the classification proletariat refers to one who is required to sell their labor to the bourgeoisie factory owners as a means to get by; however, they will never own any means of production, nor will they consume the product by which they produce. By this definition -contrary to what Stalin argues- the Russian Revolution was not a proletariat revolution, but rather, it would be classified as a populist revolution. It is adjacent to a left leaning social-populist definition focusing on “anti-elitist sentiments, opposition to the establishment and speaking for the common people,” though, it can also apply to a more conservative definition: creating a movement which is meant to mirror the most popular opinions in a given society. The revolution was fought against a tyranny of the Romanov Royal Family and of the Ruling Class -the minority (around 12% of the population)- and fought by the substantially larger non gubernatorial Russian citizenry (82%

Peasant, 1% Kulak, 1.5% Middle Class, and 4% Working class). The revolutionaries were not classified by their acquisition of labor, nor were they classified by their lack of consumption, they were classified by being subjects of the Tsar, and by being the majority. The abundant peasantry is not the proletariat, they are viewed differently, and with disdain by Marx and Engels, and thereby the revolution is not even a populist proletariat revolution -a revolution where the proletariat is the most abundant group. The proletariat is the 4%, the working class, who applies their labor though does not reap benefits or own factors of production like the middle class does; they are not the peasantry. As previously stated, the revolution was to bring the views of the majority- the commoners.

Secondarily, Stalin describes that Leninism is “the theory and tactics of the dictatorship of the proletariat in particular.” In this definition, Stalin applied an incredibly tactical play: he completely redefined Marxism to be a means to amass power in an individual or small group, rather than a large comune. While this phrase, the dictatorship of the proletariat, was uttered by Marx, it was used interchangeably with the phrases “the rule of the proletariat” and “political power held by the working class” -both of which were used much more frequently. The definition which Stalin uses -as evidenced by his later time as General Secretary- is not Marxist. Marxism’s goal is to return the power to the workers, and to disband autocracy or oligarchy, not to empower an oligarchical body which attempts to represent the people. If Marxism is based on class struggle, and hopes to destroy all of society as a means to abolish class struggle, then creating a ruling class cannot occur. Furthermore, if Stalin’s definition of the Soviet dictatorship was accurate -which it was not, as slowly the dictatorship grew distant from the desires of the majority of Russia- Stalin would once again be describing an populist regime -albeit an authoritarian one. Therein, the Russian Revolution would not meet the Marxist definition -it is focused on the majority getting to enact their will, and ultimately get that will enacted through an authoritarian oligarchy. Marxist-Leninist theory began as the theory of authoritarian populism.

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What Does Lenin Keep From Marx?

While Lenin departed from Marxism in many ways, the main core doctrine he kept is the need for destructive violence -though, it is viewed through a Stalinist lens. A good example of this violence is how Lenin responds to the issue of the 1918 food protests. In response to large scale starvation, protests began to rise in Petrograd (modern day St Petersburg) just a year into Lenin’s ruling of Russia. Lenin explained to Presidium of the Petrograd that “We can’t expect to get anywhere unless we resort to terrorism: speculators

must be shot on the spot” The call for the destruction of society present in Marxism normalized violence as a means to an end, and Stalin’s revision of a dictatorship of the proletariat entitled the power to an organized gubernatorial body. Therein, centralized repressive violence is permitted, and grows to be the norm in these Marxist societies, even though Marx himself would not wish the repression to be centralized. As the citizenry grows dissatisfied with the conditions brought about by Communism -with the citizenry even voting against the Bolsheviks 75% to 25% in the 1917 Constituent Assembly elections- repressive violence becomes the only way to keep order. The Bolsheviks are no longer populist as their citizenry votes against them, and their proletariats become disenchanted. This moment is where Marxist-Leninism shifts from authoritarian populism to authoritarian repressive control. The shift, when practically applied, re-establishes the problem Marxism set out to eliminate in the first place -class disparities. With the risk of excessive reiteration, the Petrograd Food Protests serve as an incredible example of this oppressor, oppressed disparity. In those protests there is the proletariat -the workers- working with the hope of surviving -not starving to death- and beginning to face unsatisfactory working conditions -starvation. They then voice their concern to the ruling class, and are met with terroristic violent repression. The Bolsheviks become the oppressors, and the proletariats stay the oppressed.

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The Logical Climax of Marxist-Leninism: Stalinism

Stalinism, though it is sometimes viewed as separate from the ideologies of Marx and Lenin, is intrinsically linked: it is not a new ideology, it simply builds off of Marxism and Leninism. While many different schools of thought exist on Stalinism, John Merriman of Yale University has a good base definition of this ideology. Merriman explains in his European Civilization lecture series that Stalinism primarily centers on having “Democratic Centralist” decision making while employing “State coercion [and] state terror.” Additionally, he argues it focuses on transforming an economically backwards society through an “obsession [on] heavy industries...built on the backs of the peasantry” who will eventually lose their private land and become industrial workers. This definition is a good starting point, and most definitely serves as the logical conclusion to Marxist-Leninism. Lenin himself actually feared Stalin being too extreme -and, most likely, as too far removed from Marxism. Lenin, in his testament written prior to his death in the aftermath of his first stroke, warned that Stalin should not be placed as General Secretary as “Comrade Stalin... has concentrated an enormous power in his hands; and I am not sure that he always knows

how to use that power with sufficient caution.” Even Lenin, who was seemingly fine with authoritarian repression, viewed Stalin as dangerously domineering. Just a week later, Lenin added an additional postscript to his testament arguing that Stalin must be removed from the government. It seems perplexing Lenin would feel so passionately against Stalin.

The Application of Stalinism

10

The epitome of Stalinism is his Five Year Plan, and understanding it is crucial to understanding this ideology. The first Five Year Plan set out to collectivise agriculture, and shift the rural agrarian economy to an urban heavily industrialized manufacturing superpower. Ultimately, Stalin's plan follows the 'Guns and Butter' economic model. In line with the Product Possibilities Frontier (PPF) curve, to increase military production as a means of strengthening national defense -which was the main utilitarian goal of industrialization- a tradeoff must be made, and domestic civilian goods must be sacrificed. With this model being mainly applied to agriculture, mass famine swept across the Soviet Union. In response, farmers began to resist collectivization and hoard their own crops, as they feared political unrest could lead to supply chain issues, and eventually to starvation. Stalin responded by sending some of these farmers -who he labeled 'Kulaks'- to concentration camps, by deporting some to remote outskirts for required work in agriculture or industry, and by exiling some to infertile wetlands. In just three years, this response affected around 1.2 million people, and continued to affect people in the years afterwards. Stalin treated almost every problem he faced similarly: if there was any instability to his power, he would utilize mass violence and terrorism -more intense, or at least on a greater scale, than that hypothesized by Lenin- as a means to neutralize the threat. Furthermore, possibly due to mental illness, Stalin had intensive paranoia, and so widespread violence and repression became a near constant in the USSR. It seems as though this is what Lenin predicted in his Testament: Stalin was simply too repressive and power hungry to be a Marxist-Leninist. Therein, he spins off from Marxist-Leninism creating Stalinism; a terror based industrial maximizing totalitarian military dictatorship. This very form of government is close to the epitome of an oppressor, and is actually much more radically oppressive than the factory owners of 1840s Germany or the ruling class of Tsarist Russia.

The Modern Importance of Understanding Marxism, Leninism, and Stalinism

In the United States -as well as more broadly across the world- as of late, many left leaning progressives have become followers of Marx, and Lenin Apologetics; people

have grown to view “Communism Through Rose-Colored Glasses.” For example, in 2018, Progressive Jason Barker wrote an opinion article in the New York Times arguing that modern progressivist ideas align with the ideas of Marx, and that Marx was “right.” Progressivism, however, could not be farther from Marxism; the two actually contradict each other. Marxism is inherently regressive, and destructive, whereas progressives desire progress. Where the pro-marxist misconception arises is in the idea of the oppressor oppressed archetype. Through some modern schools of thought, progressives view minority groups as the oppressed, and dominant groups as the oppressors. The reason this misconception is so strong, is because historically and currently -within non-marxist definitions- this has proven true; the hate which minorities get is oppressive, and there are oppressors causing it. Marxism, however, would not provide the desired solution. Often modern progressives seek equity, where the marginalized can be holstered up to account for past oppression. Marxism does not deliver equity. Rather, Marxism delivers equality in poverty, where both the minority and the dominant group become equally poor, and the oppressed are not upholstered at all. This is not a progressive dream in the slightest. It is Faustian: it causes greater poverty and suffering, not less. Additionally, the ‘Lenin Apologists’ do not stand on solid footing. In an article for Current Affairs in response to an article by Bret Stephens, Socialist Nathan J. Robinson argues that Stephens is right about one thing: some fellow left leaning people justify Marx and Lenin as progressive, and they shouldn’t. Robinson argues that the socialism progressives seek -that of welfare programs, equity, increased social services, and increased well being- is not Marxism, nor is it Leninism, and to argue for either of those is actually contrary to progressive socialism. The political right is incredibly accurate in their assessment of the dangers of Marxism. It seems, while there are certainly critiques of Socialism -even from the lens of how it affects national progress- it is important for those who seek social progress to not fall into the trap of supporting Marx or Lenin -the two are inherently contradictory to the goals of both the American Right, and the American Left. Being a socialist does not require being a Marxist, or supporting Lenin. There is an incredible symbol of the danger of the Marxist and Leninist ideas contrasted against the opportunity of Western Liberal ideas visible in the past. In the aftermath of the Second World War, Germany was split between the Western powers and the Eastern USSR by the Berlin Wall. The wall was described in East German propaganda as protecting Eastern freedom, serving as an “antifascist protective rampart” to keep out Western Fascism. However, this proved inaccurate, and the living conditions in East Germany were repressive and dystopian, compared to a much more progressive West Germany. Ultimately, the purpose of

HENRY MANNINO

the wall was to concede West Germany between the progressive Western Powers, and keep The West from destroying the power of the regressive Eastern USSR regime; ultimately, the wall did not serve to protect against a wave of fascism, but to block a wave of progressive freedoms from eroding the Soviet Dystopia.



—
“The Fall of the Berlin Wall” Herbert Smagon, 1989

CITATIONS

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The Teapot Dome Scandal

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The United States Navy transitioned from coal to oil-powered ships in the early 1910s due to the significant advantages in speed and efficiency. USS Nevada-class battle-ships were designed to be entirely coal-free by 1911. As a result, the Navy became concerned about securing a reliable oil supply. In 1912, President William Howard Taft established the first Naval Petroleum Reserves, which designated areas of land containing significant oil deposits exclusively for use by the Navy. Naval Petroleum Reserve Number 1 was established in Elk Hills, California, and Naval Petroleum Reserve Number 3 was established in Salt Creek, Wyoming. The Salt Creek oil reserve was known as Teapot Dome due to the oil rock being teapot-shaped. The reserves were intended to provide an oil supply for the Navy during times of national emergency. World War I emphasized the importance of oil in modern warfare and contributed to a growing awareness of potential oil shortages in a globalized landscape. The early 20th century also saw the rapid growth of the oil industry. Many individual fortunes were created by exploiting newly discovered fields. These so-called "oil tycoons" had significant political and economic influence. Edward Doheny was a leading tycoon and pioneer in the California oil industry. His oil company, Pan American Petroleum and Transport Company, was a major player in the global market. Harry Sinclair was another prominent tycoon and the founder of Mammoth Oil Co. The naval oil reserves represented a valuable source of oil, and for Doheny and Sinclair, gaining access to these reserves was a lucrative opportunity.

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On March 4, 1921, Warren Harding was inaugurated as the 29th president of the United States. On the same day, Harding announced his cabinet picks, including Albert

Fall for Secretary of the Interior. Fall was previously a senator from New Mexico and was acquainted with Harding from the Senate. Fall gained control of the oil reserves in May and, in July, leased Elk Hills to Doheny. The lease was granted without competitive bidding. Doheny later provided Fall with \$100,000, describing it as a loan. In February 1922, Fall leased Teapot Dome to Sinclair. The Wall Street Journal published news of questionable dealings on the part of Fall in April 1922, as rumors circulated that alleged that he was accepting bribes. On January 2, 1923, Fall announced his resignation effective March 4th. A Senate Committee headed by Senator Thomas Walsh of Montana announced an investigation into Fall's actions in March 1923. On August 2, 1923, Harding died of a heart attack in San Francisco while on a western tour. He served as President for 882 days, the fourth shortest term in presidential history. Harding was succeeded by Vice President Calvin Coolidge. Coolidge, in a statement on the Teapot Dome investigation, stated that the "public is entitled to know that in the conduct of such actions no one is shielded from any party, political, or other reasons... I propose to employ special counsel of high rank, drawn from both political parties, to bring such actions for the enforcement of the law." Coolidge appointed two investigators, Owen Roberts- a Republican from Philadelphia, and later an Associate Justice of the Supreme Court- and Senator Atlee Pomerance, a Democrat from Ohio. In February 1924, the Senate investigation found that Fall received large sums of money in exchange for rights over the reserves. Sinclair and Doheny were implicated in the investigation. Between 1924 and 1927, Walsh and the Senate Committee on Public Lands investigated Fall. In 1927, the Supreme Court invalidated the Elk Hills and Teapot Dome oil leases. Fall was charged with accepting bribes in March 1927. He was the first cabinet member to be convicted of a felony and was sentenced to one year in prison in 1929. Sinclair and Doheny were acquitted but faced public scrutiny. Historical evidence suggests that the Teapot Dome Scandal weakened public trust in the government by exposing high-level corruption and abuses of power. Additionally, the scandal revealed the government's vulnerability to corruption and tarnished the Harding administration's image. The scandal solidified Congress's role in executive oversight, empowering Congress to later confront and hold accountable the Nixon administration during the Watergate scandal.

The Senate investigation and newspaper reporting revealed the quid pro quo of oil reserves for compensation, weakening public trust in the Harding administration. According to historian Allen Pussey, "Fall began lobbying Harding to wrest control over the reserves," even before Harding was inaugurated. Fall's lobbying of Harding before the in-

auguration highlights a deliberate attempt to exploit their relationship. In 1921, President Harding issued Presidential Executive Order 3474, granting the Department of the Interior full control over the oil reserves. It stated that “the Secretary of the Interior is authorized and directed to perform any and all acts necessary for the protection, conservation, and administration of the said reserves subject to the conditions and limitations contained in this order and the existing laws or such laws as may hereafter be enacted by Congress pertaining thereto.” The executive order granted the Department of the Interior broad authority over the oil reserves and empowered Fall to make decisions with minimal oversight. The broadness was intentional, as Theodore Roosevelt Jr, the assistant Secretary of the Navy under Secretary Edwin Denby, stated that the Executive Order was “written by Fall and with Denby’s approval [given] to President Harding [who] then signed it,” suggesting Fall deliberately intended there to be little oversight. After Fall was given control over the oil reserves, he “negotiated lease agreements with private oil companies that provided the navy with refined oil for storage (in exchange for crude), as well as agreements to build oil facilities for both the Pacific and Atlantic.” Fall’s choice to assign the leases rather than establish a competitive bidding process showcases his intention to benefit from the deals. Competitive bidding to ensure fairness and the best deal for the government was standard practice. Instead, Fall steered the contracts to favored companies in exchange for compensation. In April 1922, Mammoth Oil Co. “secretly agreed to build a pipeline and stock the Navy’s East Coast storage tanks in exchange for full control of [Teapot Dome]- another no-bid, no-royalties deal.” The deal deprived the government of maximum return on its assets. Fall used his position to enrich himself and private individuals at the expense of the American taxpayers.

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The scale of corruption demonstrated how easily a government institution could be manipulated. During the investigation into Fall, Walsh secured testimony from an Albuquerque newspaper editor, Carl Magee, who stated that Fall’s property had undergone significant upgrades, paid for by Doheny. Magee testified that “the conditions were so changed that I couldn’t recognize it.” The description of Fall’s home reinforced the idea that the government’s safeguards and oversight were inadequate. Magee’s testimony suggests that the system failed to police itself, as the government had not uncovered Fall’s unethical behavior. In his inaugural address on March 4, 1921, Harding stated that “Our most dangerous tendency is to expect too much of government, and at the same time do for it too little.” Harding argued that the public viewed the government as an entity capable of solving problems, while the scandal exposed corruption stemming from unchecked

power.

Americans' willingness to trust their government without demanding accountability created a fertile ground for exploitation. When investigating the scandal, Walsh said "The climax was reached when on January 24 Doheny voluntarily appeared to tell that on November 30, 1921, he had loaned \$100,000 to Fall without security, moved by old friendship and commiseration for his business misfortunes...he secured, without competition, a contract giving him a preference right to a lease of a large part of Naval Reserve No. 1, to be followed by the lease of the whole of it." The statement exposes how easily Fall's judgment was compromised by money and manipulated through personal relationships. Doheny's attempt to justify the loan based on personal sentiment reveals vulnerability to emotional appeals. Additionally, Doheny's voluntary appearance suggests he attempted to portray himself as innocent. According to *The New York Times*, the oil executives were "charged by the United States Government with having engineered an oil deal out of which, it is alleged, Mr. Fall received more than \$80,000 in liberty bonds." The oil deal implies that the executives provided compensation to government officials in exchange for being granted favorable treatment. Payment in Liberty Bonds shows a calculated attempt to hide the real reason for the bond exchange. Furthermore, as a Congressional probe was gearing up, "Sinclair gave \$269,000 in Liberty Bonds and cash to Fall's son-in-law, M.T. Everhart, who delivered the bundle to Fall." Sinclair continued to provide payments even as an investigation was underway, suggesting his high level of confidence that the government was vulnerable to influence. The use of family to transfer the funds shows deliberate planning to hide corruption. Fall and Sinclair believed that if they were careful, they could evade detection even with the investigation looming. It was later revealed that Sinclair gifted "a lot of fancy cattle and horses to Fall." Extravagant gifts indicate a significant personal benefit for Fall. Accepting such lavish gifts is still bribery, as government officials could be easily influenced by non-monetary benefits.

The revelations of unethical private sector behavior were matched by the discovery of high-level corruption in the government. During Walsh's investigation, he discovered that "in November 1921, Doheny's son, Edward Jr, arrived at Fall's apartment bearing a black bag containing [cash]." The delivery of cash directly to Fall shows that he directly profited from his illicit actions. This sum, delivered clandestinely, strongly suggests that Fall and Doheny were trying to keep their actions and deal secret from those in the government. The magnitude of the sum of money highlights the potential favors that Fall was expected to deliver to the oil executives. Additionally, the fact that the money was delivered

directly to Fall at his home establishes that the pair wanted to bypass any official record. Furthermore, Edward Doheny Jr. personally delivered the cash, underscoring the importance of trusting few people with the knowledge of their actions. In the 1927 legal case, *United States v Mammoth Oil Co*, stemming from the Teapot Dome scandal, the court stated that "If a government official, engaged in making contracts for the government, receives pecuniary favor from one with whom such contracts are made, a fraud is committed on the government." The court emphasizes that the illicit actions done by Fall during the scandal were a breach of trust and a form of corruption.

The careful planning and weak alibis contributed to a loss of public trust in the Harding administration. Following the transfer of the oil reserves to the Department of the Interior, Fall "then followed intimations of Mr. Sinclair to Three Rivers of confidential conferences between Mr. Fall and Edward L. Doheny, all of them attending the negotiations that culminated in the transfer of the Navy's great oil reserves to the interests dominated by those two oil men." Fall's involvement in the conferences demonstrates premeditated corruption. The deals violated the public's expectation of a fair and transparent form of government. Transferring of public resources to private investors without adequate compensation erodes the public's trust in the government. These meetings suggest that the corruption was planned from the start. In a letter from Pomerene to Everhart, Pomerene wrote, "Our contention is that in the bribery case, evidence of similar transactions is competent for the purpose of showing the intent; in other words, to characterize the end. It will be contended on the part of the defendant that the \$100,000 was a loan. You and I feel confident that it was never intended that it should be repaid. Similarly, the Sinclair-Fall transaction in the form it took was a mere ruse." The letter revealed that the prosecution was building a case against Fall on a pattern of corrupt behavior. Pomerene also made clear they were not simply interested in the fact that the money changed hands but also in Fall's motives. Fall's attempts to disguise the bribes as loans and normal contracts showcased a calculated level of deception. During the investigation, *The New York Times* reported on the case, writing that Fall "insisted that the \$100,000 loan was a legitimate transaction; that even though it was made just before the lease was given to Mr. Doheny, it was nevertheless nothing more than what Mr. Doheny said it was, namely, a loan from one friend to another. The Government contended that it made no difference whether it was a bribe, a loan, or a gift. Whatever it was, Messrs. Roberts and Pomerene insisted, there was but one construction to put it on, namely that the money went to Fall to influence his actions in the matter of the disposition of Elk Hills." Fall's insistence that the loans were a legitimate transaction

reveals his attempts at a cover-up. The pair claiming that the loan was friendly implies that they knew they had done something wrong. In a hearing before an enraged Congress, "oil and gas experts estimated that Fall had given away at least \$100 million (\$1.5 billion today) in government-owned oil for little or nothing." Experts provided concrete evidence of the massive scale of corruption.

The repercussions of the scandal damaged the reputation of President Harding's administration and cast a shadow over his legacy. Most historians of the modern era consider Harding to be "the worst of all American Presidents." The scandal left a lasting stain on Harding's legacy, solidifying his place in history as a symbol of systematic corruption. In a letter to Fall, Harding wrote that "I have no concerns about Wyoming oil matters. I am confident you have adopted the correct policy and will carry it through in a way altogether to be approved." Harding had complete trust in Fall regarding matters of significant public importance. The blind trust reveals a critical failure of oversight. Harding's mismanagement of Fall was a key factor in allowing corruption to occur. Additionally, Harding's writing implies and endorses Fall's action, creating the idea that Harding was complicit. In a meeting with historian Nicholas Murray Butler, Harding admitted that he was "not for this office and should never have been there." Harding's reflection suggests that he recognizes the gravity of the situation and the poor decisions he made that put corrupt officials in charge. He realized that his judgment was flawed, and he put the trust of the American people into the wrong hands.

The President's damaged legacy was largely the result of a lack of oversight and failure to be aware of the corruption. George Norris, a senator from Nebraska, wrote about the scandal in his autobiography, saying that the scandal "had its origin in the early months of the Harding administration. It became the subject of common gossip in Washington, and yet no betrayal of public trust resisted exposure and punishment more tenaciously." Norris implies a degree of responsibility and a failure of oversight within the administration. The scandal's oversight issues suggest the corruption was a systematic issue within Harding's government and not just an isolated incident. Norris's description of the scandal as common gossip implies that it was a prominent topic of discussion, reflecting a loss of confidence. Furthermore, the scandal was not just a rumor but a widely discussed topic, suggesting that the government was aware of the potential wrongdoings yet did nothing to stop it. The widespread awareness and lack of action led to distrust in Harding's administration. Norris implies that the administration and involved parties actively worked to conceal their actions, further eroding the public's trust when the truth broke. In January

1923, Harding complained to newspaper editor William Allen White that he had “no trouble with my enemies. I can take care of my enemies all right. But my damn friends, my god-damned friends, White, they’re the ones who keep me walking the floor nights!” At its core, Teapot Dome was a betrayal of trust by people within Harding’s circle. The scandal was not the work of external enemies but of those close to him. Harding was not entirely ignorant of the corruption of his administration, even if he was not directly responsible. Later, Norris noted that “out of it came the evidence supporting the inescapable conviction that immense combinations of wealth, large corporations, under leases fraudulently obtained, were systematically robbing the government of the oil stored in the public lands by Nature.” The scandal involved powerful people, implying that Harding enabled corruption within his administration. Additionally, the government being robbed painted Harding as a weak leader who could not control his cabinet. Historian John Dean states that “the fact that Harding had done nothing wrong and had not been involved in any criminal activities became irrelevant.” The scandal’s impact on Harding’s administration’s reputation was so intense that his innocence did not make a difference in his legacy.

The Congressional response to Fall’s plans had implications for future presidents. The scandal set critical precedents that enabled the investigation of the Watergate Scandal under Richard Nixon to be effective. Congress had concrete power to investigate the executive branch’s actions. In the early 1970s, as Nixon prepared to run for re-election, his administration became increasingly concerned about political opposition. Nixon’s aides created a covert unit known as the “plumbers,” tasked with stopping government leaks. Over time, the group expanded its role to include illegal activities aimed at discrediting opponents. The Plumbers planned break-ins and surveillance operations. On June 17, 1972, five men were arrested for breaking into the Democratic National Committee headquarters at the Watergate Office Buildings. In January 1973, the Senate Select Committee on Presidential Campaign Activities was created to investigate the Watergate break-in. The committee, led by Senator Sam Ervin (D-NC), drew on the investigative framework established during the Teapot Dome investigation. The Watergate committee used the precedent to assert its right to investigate misconduct that was linked to the president. They relied on many similar investigative pieces, such as demanding internal documents, subpoenaing witnesses, and holding public hearings. During the Teapot Dome, public outrage over corrupted government officials led to discussions about whether or not independent legal figures were needed to avoid conflicts of interest during investigations into the executive branch. While the Nixon administration initially tried to contain the scandal, under pressure from

Congress and the media, Attorney General Elliot Richardson appointed a special prosecutor- Archibald Cox- in 1973. Cox demanded the secret White House tapes that could prove Nixon's involvement with the June 1972 break-in. Nixon refused and ordered Cox's firing on October 20th. As it became known, the "Saturday Night Massacre" triggered massive public and political backlash. Richards and Deputy Attorney General William Ruckelshaus resigned in protest. During the Teapot Dome, newspapers' demand for accountability played an important part in creating political momentum for sustained investigations. Much of the government hoped the scandal would quietly fade, but persistent reporting forced the Senate to act. The dynamic of media coverage fueling public demand for justice set an important precedent that would be followed during Watergate. Investigative journalism by Bob Woodward and Carl Bernstein, formerly of The Washington Post, proved critical in the early stages of the scandal. They connected the break-in at the Watergate complex to Nixon's re-election campaign. Their words kept public attention focused on the case. The Teapot Dome investigation's outcome showed the American public for the first time that top officials would be held legally accountable, regardless of the position they held. The Watergate investigation led to the indictment and conviction and 25 people, including top Nixon aides, such as John Mitchell and John Ehrlichman. President Nixon resigned in 1974 to avoid impeachment, becoming the first US president to do so.

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HOW MILITARY ESCALATION OVERSHADOWED AN ENTIRE PRESIDENCY

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On November 1, 1955, North Vietnam and the United States of America engaged in what would be a 20-year war. The Vietnam War was a complex conflict which involved multiple different actors and motivations. The United States of America became involved primarily due to its Cold War strategy of containing communism, fearing the spread of communist throughout Southeast Asia. U.S. involvement escalated significantly during the middle of the 1960s, with a gradual deployment of troops and increased aerial bombardment of North Vietnam. The war was marked by significant casualties on both sides, mounting public opposition in the United States, and ultimately led to U.S. withdrawal and the reunification of Vietnam under communist rule. John F. Kennedy had been President for about two-and-a-half years during the Vietnam War, until his assassination on November 22, 1963. Vice President Lyndon B. Johnson was immediately sworn in and assumed the presidency. Johnson decided to send military forces to stop the spread of communism in Southeast Asia. However, as the war continued to drag on, the people began to protest, which reflected negatively on President Johnson. Johnson increased the country's involvement in the Vietnam War due to his fear of communist expansion, which ultimately overshadowed many of his positive presidential achievements – the expansion of accessible healthcare, social welfare, and education – resulting in a tainted presidential legacy.

Johnson escalated the United States' military presence quite early in his presidency in an attempt to contain communism due to his fear of its spread throughout Southeast Asia and, ultimately, to other democracies. This apprehension was largely based on the "Domino Theory," where if one country "falls" to communism, then other countries will soon follow and start a chain reaction of adhering to communism. Johnson's fear was that the U.S. would be taken over by communist ideals and lose its democracy. One of the

earliest debated causes for the U.S. military escalation was the Gulf of Tonkin Incident. In August of 1964, editors for History.com detailed how “DRV torpedo boats attacked two U.S. destroyers in the Gulf of Tonkin,” after Johnson ordered the retaliatory bombing of military targets in North Vietnam.” The U.S. used this event to justify increasing its military involvement as well as gaining congressional support through the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution. This Resolution gave Johnson “war-making powers, and U.S. planes began regular bombing raids” the following year. The U.S. Office of the Historian said “Congress supported the resolution with the assumption that the president would return and seek their support before engaging in additional escalations of the war.” Debates still persist on whether the Gulf of Tonkin was exaggerated to attain Congress’s near-unanimous approval to give Johnson free reign on military matters in Vietnam.

Alongside Johnson’s military escalation were the bombing attempts on North Vietnam, one of the most notable being “Operation Rolling Thunder,” which “commenced on February 13, 1965 and continued through the spring of 1967.” This two-year prolonged bombing campaign aimed to weaken North Vietnam’s ability to fight by bombing its supply routes and infrastructure, an attempt to apply military pressure and force North Vietnam into negotiations. However, it failed to lessen Vietnam’s ability to fight back and actually led to the hardening of North Vietnam’s resolve to resist the U.S instead. At the same time, Johnson started making more progress through his Great Society program: expanding healthcare access through Medicare and Medicaid, creating better and more accessible education, and fighting against poverty. Regarding his stance on the war, however, Johnson only lessened the U.S. military escalation due to internal opposition, financial stress and lack of progress. He also feared that escalating too quickly might provoke China or the Soviet Union into an even larger conflict. However, in his attempt to prevent an international crisis, Johnson caused an internal one. This small decision gave North Vietnam time to adapt and plan accordingly for future offensives. This slow increase in military pressure unfortunately led to a longer, more drawn out war and came to define Johnson’s Presidency, overshadowing progressive achievements he had made, as outlined by the Miller Center, State.gov, PBS Timeline.

Meanwhile, back in the United States, public protests and movements against the Vietnam War raged in the streets and college campuses. As the war dragged on, the early optimism of Americans slowly turned to skepticism and widespread distrust of the U.S government and President Johnson. Young men were coming home in body bags every day, as the cost was increasing, and it seemed there was no point to the war. Thus, citizens

began to join the growing anti-war protests putting more pressure on Johnson to de-escalate the war.

A key turning point in the shaping of public opinion was the Tet Offensive. In January 1968 the North Vietnamese forces produced a series of surprise attacks on U.S. bases and South Vietnamese cities during what was actually supposed to be a holiday ceasefire. Even though the attacks were a military setback for the Viet Cong (North Vietnamese), they had a significant psychological impact on the American public. The strikes were so shocking to the average citizen, who had been led to believe that the U.S. was making steady progress in the war: television broadcasts and newspapers which brought highly graphic images of violence demonstrated to the average citizen what was really occurring overseas. According to the National Archives and Britannica, the sharing of this specific media played a crucial role in eroding public confidence and pushing anti-war sentiment across the country. Draft resistance also began to surge, for many young men started to burn their draft cards, fled to other countries, or even faced jail time rather than fighting in the horrible conditions displayed across the media. All of the circulating media insisted on making the average American citizen question the real motives behind the conflict and questioned their support of it. Through all of this chaos and unrest, Johnson started to be seen more as a symbol of war instead of being recognized for all of his positive progressive movements.

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With America starting to question the motivation behind the war, Johnson decided it would be best for him to not re-run for presidency. As the amount of pressure increased from all sides, Johnson declared on March 31, 1968, that he would not seek re-election. Johnson's decision was significantly swayed by the absurdly large toll the war had taken on both the country and his presidency. This 20-year long war had cost the lives of over 58,000 American soldiers and left even more wounded. When new media was published or broadcasted about still more casualties, it only further decreased Johnson's popularity. Indeed, the polls showed declining support –even among those who once fully supported him without hesitation. Such a large loss of life made it extremely hard for any Americans to justify continuing the war. People looked for someone to blame, and despite the war's beginning during John F. Kennedy's term, all seemed to point to one person: Lyndon B. Johnson. Though President Kennedy significantly increased U.S. involvement in Vietnam, he did not "start" the war in the sense of launching a full-scale military conflict. Previous presidents, such as Eisenhower and Truman, laid the groundwork for U.S. involvement. Kennedy's actions, such as increasing the number of military advisors and authorizing

covert operations, marked a shift towards a more active role. However, the full-scale war escalated under President Johnson. The war also created a huge financial issue within the United States economy, making it more difficult for Johnson to support domestic social reforms -one of the many things he was once praised for. Johnson was once someone who had been celebrated and known for his plans for civil rights as well as his programs to reduce poverty, but ultimately his role in the Vietnam War overshadowed all of his other achievements. In the end, Johnson's decision to not re-run for presidency was both a personal and political understanding of how he had affected the nation as a whole. As he stepped down, his spot remained open and led to a rush towards his seat, while the country still had to grapple with the consequences of what his presidency had left behind. When Richard Nixon became president on January 20, 1969, he began withdrawing troops from Vietnam; with the fall of the capital of South Vietnam, Saigon, in 1975, the war was finally over.

Lyndon B. Johnson's legacy remains somewhat complex, for both public praise on his progressive policies, but also criticism for his handling of the Vietnam War. As the Vietnam War escalated and mass casualties rose, Johnson's image began to shift from a respected social reformer to a president who made the wrong decisions in an attempt to win an unwinnable war. Johnson's decision to dramatically increase his military presence in the area as well as authorize many bombing campaigns placed him at the center of anti-war propaganda. This shift caused many Americans to no longer look at him as a reformer, but instead as a villain who had cost thousands of lives to be lost and divided the nation. Scholars from Millar Center, Vassar.edu, and Alpha History have added to the continual debate about whether people can fully appreciate Johnson's domestic accomplishments due to his major impacts on the Vietnam War.

Lyndon B. Johnson's increased U.S. involvement in the Vietnam War due to his fear of communist expansion, ultimately overshadowed the good he did with his expansion of accessible healthcare, social welfare, and education and ended up negatively defining both his presidency and legacy. His total commitment to the warring effort, despite all of the public disapproval, led to a sharp decline in public trust. President Johnson's tainted legacy was a result of his overzealous position on the Vietnam War and his lack of regard for what Americans - who elected him - truly wanted, an end to the war. He was blind in his ambition and the thousands of names engraved on the Vietnam War Memorial testify to that.

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Economic Shields and Retaliation to Political Shifts

The Legacy of the Smoot-Hawley Tariff

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Introduction

In May of 1930, more than a thousand economists from forty-six states and 179 colleges across the United States signed a letter to President Herbert Hoover, Senator Reed Smoot, and Representative Willis Hawley, expressing their alarm in regard to the proposed Tariff Act of 1930. Unequivocally, they claimed, “the pending bill will raise the cost of living and injure the ‘majority of our citizens’” (Special to The New York Times “1,028 Economists,” 1930, p. 1). Both the House and the Senate passed the tariff, and the President had the opportunity to veto the bill and heed to the concerns of the American Economic Association. Yet, President Hoover’s conviction that the tariff would benefit Americans and boost the economy encouraged him to approve the Smoot-Hawley Tariff of 1930, an act that still offers important lessons for the entire world. In an attempt to support American farmers and businesses during economic hardships in the 1920s, the Tariff Act of 1930 achieved the antithesis: reaching the apex of a protectionist policy, the tariff worsened the decline of the economy during the Great Depression and harmed U.S. diplomatic relations. In addition to many of the immediate repercussions on domestic people, industries, and international trade partners, this paper argues that the Smoot-Hawley Tariff altered U.S. trade policy by triggering global political changes and strengthening the Executive Branch with commercial power—still visible almost a hundred years later.

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Setting the Stage for Protectionism

During the nineteenth century, extensive parts of the northern United States supported taxes on imported goods, simply called tariffs, because manufacturing industries

faced foreign competition, whereas cotton and tobacco farmers in the South exported their commodities abroad, making tariffs placed on other countries a barrier to these industries because of lowering exports. The Republican Party became more tied to this protectionist economic framework, especially after the Civil War. After Republican Benjamin Harrison defeated Democrat Grover Cleveland in 1888, President Harrison's administration endorsed the idea of further protection for American industry. The McKinley Tariff followed, setting the tariff rate to a record high of 48 percent and beginning a pattern of foreign retaliation along with greater U.S. protectionism (Plant, 2004). The Payne-Aldrich Tariff was another major tariff bill enacted in 1909 by a Republican-controlled Congress, but this bill aimed to lower the average tariff rate on imported goods; nevertheless, the act ended up increasing duties on several goods such as iron ore and coal (Plant, 2004). These tariff increases ultimately angered the progressive wing of the Republican party, as President William Howard Taft failed to fulfill his promise of reducing tariff rates.

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While nationwide controversy surrounded tariffs, the purpose of tariffs evolved during the early twentieth century. Until 1913, the national government imposed tariffs as a tool for federal revenue and protection of domestic industries; the introduction of income tax in 1913 replaced the need for tariffs to generate federal revenue, so tariffs were passed to focus on protecting U.S. industries (Irwin, 2017, p. 11). That same year, President Woodrow Wilson asserted his commitment to reforming U.S. trade policies and supported the Underwood-Simmons Tariff of 1913, named after Representative Oscar Underwood and Senator F.M. Simmons, that removed tariff duties on products such as iron, farm equipment, raw materials, linen, and foods.

Unfortunately, these tariff reductions achieved little since World War I was imminent after President Wilson signed this tariff. This global war took a major toll on international trade: military action across the world caused import and export levels to drop considerably. American farmers grew their production dramatically during this period, including exports of food to Europe, but European recovery in the agricultural industry created a "surplus" of productive capacity and the prices for farm commodities plummeted" (Striner, 2018, p. 63). Thus, during the 1920s, rural America faced the problem of economic depression yet again, and legislators worked on remedies such as inflationism, particularly maintaining a stable and predictable inflation rate to prevent uncertainty and incentivize investment, and other measures to support domestic agricultural businesses. The fragile post-World War I economy provoked Congressman Joseph W. Fordney and Senator Porter J. McCumber to architect the Fordney-McCumber Tariff of 1922 that in-

corporated higher average taxes on imported goods to protect U.S. manufacturers from European producers (“Fordney-McCumber Tariff,” 2015). Still, imports of farm goods rose in the United States, and farmers advocated for further legislation: the Smoot-Hawley Tariff answered the call.

People remember the names of Senate Finance Committee chairman Reed Smoot and House Ways and Means Committee chairman Willis Hawley even today, mostly in conjunction with the economic debacle that resulted from their tariff. President Hoover signed this bill in June of 1930 during the Great Depression, a major economic recession that began after the stock market crash of 1929 and subsequent bank failures and widespread panic. Before his presidency and approval of the tariff, President Hoover was known for his civic work. As Commerce Secretary, Hoover became a chief proponent of supporting initiatives to combat the economic downturn, such as advocating for a Department of Public Works, federal investments into construction programs, and public works projects to assist the unemployed (Striner, 2018, p. 62). Nonetheless, ignoring the concerns of hundreds of economists and passing the Tariff Act of 1930 exacerbated the declining economy—as much of the public predicted—and significantly reduced his popularity for the elections of 1932. Outlined in the bill and confirmed by the Tariff Commission, 93.73 percent of the taxes were upon agricultural commodities (“President Hoover,” 1930, p. 191). This concentration of import taxes on farm products ended up backfiring because of international outrage and retaliation. First, though, Americans had to face the consequences of this trade policy and decades-long effects.

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Exposing the Fragility of the Domestic Economy

During the Great Depression era, the Smoot-Hawley Tariff plunged the economy deeper into a hole and led to outrage across America. Four months after President Hoover signed the tariff into law, the daily afternoon newspaper Washington Evening Star published a cartoon of Representative Hawley “sweating bullets over heavy criticism of the Smoot-Hawley Tariff” (Image 1) (Plant, 2004).



Image 1: Published in the Washington Evening Star, October 25, 1930

Although the cartoon portrays the criticism towards Hawley effectively, the artist decided to cast a darker light on Senator Smoot for changing tariff figures, claiming that those modifications exacerbated the financial situation. Indeed, 431 modifications of the House bill took place in the Senate, and most of the increased rates were for agricultural commodities (“The Smoot-Hawley,” 1929, p. 158). Like the economists from the American Economic Association foretold, the increased tariff duties did “raise prices to consumers, damage export trade, hurt farmers, promote inefficiency and promote foreign reprisals” (Pakko, 1930). A 1939 New York Times article captured this sentiment by emphasizing Secretary of State Cordell Hull’s lament that “within two years after the Smoot-Hawley act was passed, with its guarantee of unmeasured prosperity to farmers and laborers and business men throughout the indefinite future, and especially its guarantee of steady employment with good wages for laborers...about ten or twelve million American wage-earners were out of employment” (Special to The New York Times “Hull Answers,” 1939, p. 6). The sheer amount of job losses justified the reactions from the public toward the tariff, particularly targeting Hoover, Smoot, and Hawley, and repeatedly debunked the idea that the tariff would boost the economy. Moreover, from 1929 to 1932, U.S. exports fell from \$5.4 billion to \$1.6 billion (Barnhill, 2013). World trade plummeted, and the Tariff Act of 1930 influenced much of the drop.

Prior to the enactment of this tariff, the prevalence of public concern unveiled an important feature of U.S. politics at the time: no amount of warning from the public—not even from hundreds of qualified economists across the country—would sway the bill away from being passed. Therefore, Henry Norton’s belief, published just a month before Hoover signed the tariff, that “there is little likelihood that a single vote in either the Senate or the House will be changed from ‘Yea’ to ‘Nay’ out of deference to this mass manifesto from the halls of learning” turned out to be accurate (Norton, 1930). Extending along these lines, the approvers of the tariff overlooked the immediate and long-term economic effects of such policy, and the question of approving the tariff relied on politics rather than economics; however, this act was not passed unanimously. The tariff issue, resurged from previous decades, fueled debate among the Republican and Democratic parties of the United States. The Washington Post published a picture of this polarization that further illustrated the controversy of the tariff before its passage (Image 2) (“The Smoot-Hawley,” 1929, 159).



Image 2: “Split Again” — The Washington Post

Senator Borah conveyed this dispute when he cautioned, “The more I read of the bill the less I like it” (“The Smoot-Hawley,” 1929, 159). Additionally, chairman of the Executive Committee of the Democratic National Committee Jouett Shouse brought to attention that “the motivating principle behind the proposed enactment was not protection of American industry...but a simple determination to enable special groups of industrialists to cash in on their last year’s campaign contributions” (“The Smoot-Hawley,” 1929, 159). This claim questioned the intent behind the tariff but continued to emphasize the polarizing nature of the issue.

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After the approval of the tariff a month later in June 1930, the economic downfall underscored that “the making of tariffs in this country has always been much more a matter of politics than of economic science” (Norton, 1930). Indeed, the politics of the country and its international relations may have shaped these protectionist measures, but the overlooking of economic science and historical disagreements affected both the United States and its trading partners. Yet days before enacting the tariff, President Hoover maintained “there are certain industries which cannot now successfully compete with foreign producers because of lower foreign wages and a lower cost of living... [a revision] may maintain the standard of living and may count upon steady employment” (“President Hoover,” 1930, p. 191). This deep conviction of the effectiveness of the tariff proved to be false and impacted business unpredictability. In fact, after Hoover’s approval of the tariff, “firms that relied on export markets would be concerned about how rapidly and how completely other countries would retaliate” and “firms that previously relied on imported inputs would have been concerned about how effectively and at what price domestic suppliers would be able to replace imports” (Archibald & Feldman, 1998, p. 861). Ultimately, domestic

controversy and criticism intensified political divide and uncertainty during this period while people faced drastic economic effects, ranging from immense trade declines to major unemployment. However, the controversy was not limited to the borders of the United States.

Sparking a New Trade War

While harming the domestic economy and the public's view of the federal government, the Smoot-Hawley Tariff also proved detrimental to many nations who had to reciprocate with more protective measures. U.S. duties plummeted global trade to new all-time lows, and the real gross national product (GNP) dropped by 18 percent with total export volume falling by 35 percent from 1929 to 1933—much of the economic decline due to the protectionist measures during this period (Crucini, 2006). To offset these impacts, the commercial partners of the United States imposed retaliatory measures. This consequence was not surprising, especially when New York Times articles circulated the idea in 1930 that “Foreign retaliation is not merely a possibility of the future...It is a present actuality. It finds expression not only in high tariff walls which increase the difficulty of American competition with foreign manufacturers [but also] various other restrictions which materially reduce the sales of American manufacturers abroad” (Norton, 1930). The conditions of the Great Depression certainly contributed to the urgency of protective measures, but legislators may have overlooked foreign retaliation or believed it to be unlikely.

The Smoot-Hawley Tariff further shifted U.S. foreign policy by provoking new political regimes in other countries, an impact unveiled after countries returned the favor with new taxes on U.S. exports. Under the tariff bill, the increase of sugar taxes on Cuba was a key factor in inciting a revolution on the island and overthrowing the existing leaders (Irwin, 2017, p. 8). The original government had friendly relations with the United States while the new leaders believed in more protectionist policies to counter American tariffs. Similarly, Canadian politics also changed after the tariff bill, for a pro-protectionist Conservative party rose to power in Canada after the tariff bill. The Canadian Prime Minister until 1930 was W.L. Mackenzie King, and he felt pressured to adopt policies that Progressives accepted to gain their support for the Liberal Party; despite the U.S. Fordney-McCumber Tariff in 1922 that taxed major Canadian exports such as wheat, cattle, and milk, King pursued tariff reductions (McDonald et al., 1997, pp. 803-804). However, King upheld an equal trade stance by announcing countervailing duties to the United States at his keynote address in Ontario days after the passage of the Smoot-Hawley Tariff: “We

are resolved, in the interests of the Canadian people, that our commercial relations must not be one-sided” (McDonald et al., 1997, p. 810). King emphasized that U.S. taxes on Canadian exports must be met with Canadian taxes on U.S. exports to counterbalance the inequality of trade and pressure the United States to call down the tariffs. These Canadian taxes would affect more than 25 percent of U.S. exports to Canada, according to analysis from the Department of Commerce in 1930, severely impacting trade relations between these major partners (Norton, 1930).

Meanwhile, R.B. Bennett campaigned in Quebec for the upcoming Canadian elections in July of 1930. Utilizing his strong belief about fighting against injustice of U.S. tariffs, particularly, “I will make [tariffs] fight for you. I will use them to blast a way into markets that have been closed,” and criticizing King’s policy, “Imagine a country sunk so low that the Prime Minister says he will not do his duty by his country because, if he did, he might provoke someone,” he won the role of Prime Minister, and the Conservatives gained the support of a majority of Canadians who moved away from the Liberal Party (Norton, 1930). In addition, the Conservatives secured the only majority in the Canadian Parliament between 1911 and 1958 by gaining 46 seats in 1930 (Norton, 1930). One can attribute many factors to this rare shift to the pro-protectionist Conservative party, but the Smoot-Hawley Tariff stands out as an important catalyst for this change in Canadian politics. For Mackenzie King, his alignment with tariff reductions and limited retaliatory tariffs shaped defensive reactions across Canada, and Bennett capitalized on King’s untenable strategy, became the Prime Minister, and helped Conservatives gain the majority in Parliament to reshape trade policy. Cuba and Canada are a few of many examples of global shifts to different political formations as a consequence of the Smoot-Hawley Tariff; these countries ultimately adopted more retaliatory policies to counter the protectionist American trade policy.

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The Tariff Act of 1930 also negatively changed perceptions of the United States internationally, for a trade war with any winners was essentially impossible during this period. First, the American Economic Association highlighted that this increase of tariffs failed to recognize the fabric of world trade in that the “bitterness which a policy of higher tariffs would inevitably inject into our international relations” would be drastic, considering that the World Economics Conference at the League of Nations in 1927 “adopted a resolution announcing that ‘the time has come to put an end to the increase in tariffs and to move in the opposite direction’” (Special to The New York Times “1,028 Economists,” 1930, p. 4). The fact that the United States chose to draw away from this global commercial agreement

incited criticism soon on an international scale.

In 1932, British civil servant Sir Arthur Salter attested that the tariff “‘was a turning point in world history’ for its role in unleashing the protectionism that destroyed world trade in the 1930s” (Irwin, 2017, p. 4). Such perceptions were common after the passage of the 1930 tariff, especially as people began feeling its effects soon. Harvard economist Richard Cooper claimed in 1987 that “the apparent indifference of the U.S. authorities to the implications of their actions for foreigners and the foreign retaliation that quickly followed, as threatened, helped convert what would have been otherwise a normal economic downturn into a major world depression” (Irwin, 2017, p. 4). Cooper argued that these U.S. tariff measures exacerbated the Great Depression itself for the United States and economic crises across the world, which other post-Great Depression studies corroborated. The passage of the Smoot-Hawley Tariff led to a set of immense shifts in politics, society, and the economy around the world. These harmful changes created a gap in U.S. diplomatic relations that required novel solutions to fix.

Mending U.S. Foreign Policy

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The Tariff Act of 1930 sparked a trade war with no winners and called upon a need to pursue a route of negotiation and import tax reduction to reestablish foreign relations and revive the economy. Two years after President Franklin D. Roosevelt won the presidential election over incumbent President Herbert Hoover, he passed the Reciprocal Trade Agreements Act (RTAA) to mitigate global trade conditions, restore U.S. trade relations, and encourage trade circulation. In fact, tariff reductions and new trade deals following the RTAA with countries like Canada, Britain, and nations in South America and Europe effectively increased American imports to an all-time high by 1940, from a 20-year low between 1932 and 1933 (Fishback, 2010, p. 407). The RTAA was a crucial step for improving foreign relations and rebuilding global trade.

In the U.S, the RTAA revised the trade policy authority. Considering that the Smoot-Hawley bill was the last Congressional general tariff revision after the RTAA delegated power to the president to negotiate commercial deals, the tariff bill helped set the foundation for evolving governmental trade authorities (Irwin, 2017, pp. 8-9). This shift resonated with President Hoover’s statement in 1930 that “Congressional revisions are not only disturbing to business but with all their necessary collateral surroundings in lobbies, log rolling, and the activities of group interest, are disturbing to public confidence” (Irwin, 2017, p. 90). The RTAA began the process of bestowing tariff power to the Executive

Branch in hopes of preventing the drastic tariff rate changes that occurred in Congress, especially during the Smoot-Hawley tariff revisions. In addition to the President's ability to conclude agreements with other nations for the growth of international markets, the amendment of the RTAA also gave the President authority to "proclaim, within strict limitations, such changes in rates of duty or guarantees of continuance of existing customs or excise treatment" (Fleming, 1936, p. 19). Therefore, the Roosevelt Administration remodeled trade policy authority to mitigate the severe economic crises of the 1930s and prevent future trade debacles; this shift exists as the precursor of unprecedented amounts of trade policy power to the Executive Branch of the United States.

Modern Resurgence

The Smoot-Hawley Tariff exacerbated economic conditions beyond the United States and substantially reshaped social and political frameworks in a multitude of countries. A wide range of condemnations from students, teachers, economists, and politicians beyond North America helped pave the way for reconstructing U.S. trade policy and set the path to strengthening the U.S. President's trade policy authority. A clear theme from this period was volatility that sparked defensive reactions from the United States, adopting a heavy protectionist economic framework that disregarded existing world trade agreements, diplomatic relations, and the commercial interests of U.S. trade partners, which collectively set consequences for the social, political, and economic state of the world. Entering the twenty-first century, the fact that economists and politicians still refer to the Smoot-Hawley Tariff demonstrates its significance and the magnitude of its impacts. During the first Trump Administration in 2017, for example, Secretary of Commerce Wilbur Ross underscored the importance of remembering and learning from the lessons from the Great Depression and tariff failures:

Tariffs do have a useful role in correcting inappropriate practices. I am keenly aware of [1930s-era tariff acts] and the effect that it had. If nothing else we can learn from the lesson of history. If it didn't work very well then it likely wouldn't work very well now (Shawn, 2017).

From the beginning of the second Trump Administration, a powerful wave of protectionist rebirth and "America First" ideologies struck the United States and hundreds of its allies. Economists agree that no one wins a trade war, but the current whimsical U.S. trade policy causes uncertainty in businesses, stock markets, and the prices of many commodities

used daily, even if the President of the United States employs these measures as bargaining chips. The current escalation of an unparalleled trade war led by the United States further disrupts global diplomacy and commercial interests, pressuring businesses to produce domestically and raise federal revenue in exchange for shaking financial markets worldwide (Gamio et al, 2025).

June 17, 1930 marked the passage of the Smoot-Hawley Tariff and a punishing legacy on the world. Learning from the economic history of the United States, particularly the Great Depression and several tariffs, is critical for navigating through the intricacies and fluctuations of current trade policy. Indeed, awareness of the beginnings of Executive Branch control over trade policy in the 1930s and later in the 1974 Trade Act—how the President regulates decisive power over the commercial interests of the United States, even though Article I, Section 8 of the U.S. Constitution reserves Congress the power to impose tariffs—becomes essential for people globally. Indeed, the Trump Administration circumvented Congressional approval and the historic checks and balances by declaring a national emergency on April 2, 2025 (“liberation day”) through the invocation of the International Emergency Economic Powers Act of 1977 (IEEPA) that authorizes the President to regulate U.S. commercial interests in the circumstance of a threat to national security, foreign policy, or the economy (Congress). Citing this act to impose tariffs is unprecedented but establishes the loopholes available to accumulate excessive power over foreign trade policy and to strong-arm nations to pursue U.S. political and economic interests, such as controlling drug trafficking, illegal immigration, and adhering to fossil fuel usage to “retreat on climate goals” (Friedman).

This current trade crisis calls for revisiting the Great Depression era and the Tariff Act of 1930 to recognize similar patterns of economic failures in history and create a sustainable trade policy authority framework. The 1930s period of unpredictability caused irreversible decisions that failed to consider public sentiment or even professional standpoints, and such impulsive choices must not be remodeled in the modern day. On August 29, 2025, a federal appeals court ruled that imposing tariffs or taxes on almost every country in the world is overstepping the limits of presidential power, voiding all “liberation day” tariffs until the Supreme Court makes an ultimate decision (Gabbatt & Rushe). Such checks of power are crucial for a country founded on the rule of law and separation of powers. In order to amend and maintain diplomatic relations with national partners and ensure a resilient future, this regulation of power becomes paramount for the United States of America.

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PROGRESS IN PALESTINE

How Zionist Approaches to Development Hindered Peace

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In his inaugural address, David Ben-Gurion, the founder and first prime minister of Israel, stated his aim to “strive to develop the land for the good of all its residents.” Long before official Israeli statehood, though, the Zionist project had already placed an emphasis on land development and a sense of constant improvement. The “Holy Land” itself required careful stewardship and necessitated the seemingly benevolent authority of Zionist leaders who intended to ensure the lasting stability of the Palestinian people along with their own settlement. Despite these claims, though, the region soon erupted into all-out war and has, ever since the 1890s, been one of the most contested pieces of land across the globe. Scholars have presented a variety of interpretations of the conflict’s origin, ranging from foreign intervention to mere territorial dispute to clash of civilizations, yet no one approach seems to fully encompass the scale and the nature of the issue at hand. While conflict over the land of Palestine often appeared religious or ideological in nature, it fundamentally revolved around not only the parcel of land itself but also more basic notions of land use. In short, beginning in the late nineteenth century, varying conceptions of development undermined the validity of the existing Arab Palestinian society, laying the foundation for Zionism and further confusing the broadly arbitrary distinction between modernization and so-called “Westernization.”

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The conflict is often defined as largely a problem of “real estate” (as scholar James L. Gelvin so succinctly describes it), yet this is a flawed perception: it frames the issue as a rational and practical disagreement, overlooking its ideological complications. However, it was in many ways a land-based conflict, and specifically one that arose from incompatible notions of land development and the myth of an empty and almost primitive Palestine. Long before the establishment of Mandate Palestine or the initial outbreak of armed conflict, early purchases of Palestinian land by Zionists began taking place as the ideology

surfaced among the intellectual elite of Europe in the late nineteenth century, and historian Mark LeVine describes these changes as setting the stage for the ongoing “conflictual nature” of Israeli-Palestinian relations. This land appeared to the first Zionists barren and in need of development—“a poor and backward agricultural country,” as one 1928 bulletin reflecting on nineteenth-century Palestine described it—yet LeVine empirically disproves this myth, instead citing Ottoman-era *sharika* practices as evidence of prosperity prior to Zionist occupation of the land. The near-feudal *sharika* system, which stemmed from Tanzimat-era census reform, formed a successful structure of economic development that directly refutes the idea that Palestine lacked the organization or the capacity to remain prosperous. Palestinian land had long been inhabited and farmed under the control of the Ottoman Empire, displaying consistent development in keeping with modern agricultural innovation. Even the Zionists initially recognized the presence of Palestinian institutions, aiming to achieve “conquest of land” and “conquest of labor” in their early settlements by taking direct control of existing Palestinian institutions (Gelvin 209). The theft of preexisting labor structures from Arab Palestinians functioned as a tacit acknowledgment of the region’s prosperity, and any such implication served to directly negate a Zionist founding myth that rested upon the assumption that Jewish settlement would economically benefit the people who already lived on the land. The 1917 Balfour Declaration, which added Western imperial legitimacy to the Zionist cause, included explicit provisions for the well-being of “existing non-Jewish communities” in the land; this stipulation forced Zionists to portray their cause as mutually beneficial and obscure the reality of an uprooted Palestinian people (Balfour 1). In the hidden dispossession of Palestinian jobs, land, and institutions, Zionists constructed an arbitrary distinction in ideologies as they pertained to the use of the land itself, rendering it undeveloped in the eyes of the foreign public and depicting their aims for the territory as benevolent aid to the Palestinians. Ultimately, the Zionist movement of modernization and land development fueled the misconception of an empty Palestine in need of development, eventually sparking conflict between two national movements that each championed their own approaches to land and labor.

The conflict, initiated by both the reform of the late Ottoman Empire and the rise of early Zionist ideology, resulted from a misunderstanding of modernization: by viewing that which was “Western” as that which made for the most forward-looking society, European powers and Zionists pushed for a form of semi-imperial progress that directly imitated Western societies. Zionism, a revolutionary movement that would bring sudden change to the region, appeared exceedingly modern, especially in contrast to the seemingly archaic

systems and technologies implemented in Palestine at the time. For example, technocracy, a term coined by scholar Derek Penslar referring to the intertwining of science and politics that caused the Zionist implementation of agricultural innovation and enforcement of development, became a “weapon” in the Zionist struggle for independence. Thus, Zionism was portrayed as a harbinger of modernity in the Middle East, bringing opportunities for “progress” through “technology... electricity... [and] better farm machinery,” among other improvements (Penslar and Bazelon, 8). “Modernization,” however, often represented the pervasive and hidden influence of Western powers. In pursuing innovation and development at all costs, Zionists echoed previous movements that had conflated “modernization” and “Westernization.” In the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, Tanzimat reformers and Young Turks advocated for the increase of Western influence on a declining Ottoman Empire, marketing the Gülhane Decree (a piece of 1839 doctrine that would dictate mid-nineteenth-century Ottoman reform) for “European consumption.” Profoundly Eurocentric ideals of modernity, which viewed progress through the lens of conformity to standards of Western democracy, technology, and industrialization rather than recognizing the subjectivity of such an idea, led to a struggle between the old and new, the East and West, that brought about the downfall of the Ottoman Empire. Zionism reflected similar struggles in its expectation to modernize Palestine and bring stability and salvation to its people—a naïve and ill-advised goal if ever there was one. Its imposition of Western values and ideals onto Palestine framed the conflict as, in many ways, an imperial one. In the 1890s, Theodor Herzl presented the modern Zionist movement, which resulted in the first aliya, or wave of settlement, decades prior to the Balfour Declaration—one which Gelvin compares to that of the French in Algeria. In modeling itself after Western imperial projects, early Zionism set itself up for ongoing conflict and confirmed the impossibility of peace to come.

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Late-nineteenth-century ideological developments and the early displacement of Palestinian labor began a conflict that has lasted into the present day, one that ultimately sprouted from two diverging understandings of land development and modernization. Modern criticisms of the state of Israel often describe the country as an example of settler colonialism, invoking comparisons to European colonization of the Americas. While such terminology presents a somewhat incomplete picture of a complex story, Zionist settlements did display an Orientalist view of Palestinian society that laid the groundwork for the territorial and ideological disputes to come. Orientalism, a term coined by Palestinian-American critic Edward Said referring to simplistic and stereotypical ideas of Asian

and specifically Middle Eastern culture, denigrated existing society and civilization in Palestine and led to its portrayal as backwards and undeveloped. These misconceptions not only caused a series of wars (at least five, depending on how one chooses to define the word) but also defined Western understandings of the Middle East. Stereotypical mischaracterizations of Middle Eastern societies brought about the mandate system, which was framed by the infantilization of its Arab subjects and the creation of a Western imperial savior complex, and have since influenced both scholarship and public perception surrounding the independence and self-determination of nations that, since the beginning of Western rule, have never possessed total agency. In its near-colonial logic of development and improvement, the early Zionist movement succumbed to the same tantalizing ideology of superiority, as its proponents saw Palestinian land as empty, open, and theirs for the taking. This so-called barren terrain, inhabited by a population that might as well have been invisible, would become the Promised Land of which Zionists had long dreamed, but only at the cost of Palestinian power and freedom.

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BORN TO BE BARTERED

The Role of the United States Government in Turning Guatemala's Children into Cold War Currency

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In 1983, in Zone 11 of Guatemala City, Guatemala, Blanca Luz López entrusted a full-time babysitter with the care of her three-year-old son—a common practice for working mothers like López, whose “long hours prevented them from assuming themselves the responsibilities of parenting.” López saw her son whenever she could, but one day, when she went to visit him, he was nowhere to be found. Desperate for answers, López confronted the caretaker who, unbeknownst to López, worked with Grace Larrad de Quan, a notorious illegal adoption ring leader. The caretaker claimed that she sent the boy to Larrad de Quan “for his greater safety.” Determined to reclaim her son, López begged Larrad de Quan multiple times for him, yet it took four months before Larrad de Quan agreed to return the child. Having grown “fond of [the boy],” Larrad de Quan insisted that the handoff occur during a piñata party at her residence so the boy could receive a proper goodbye. Without López’s knowledge, however, a private lawyer had already processed her son’s adoption “in exchange for an appreciable amount of money.” The process pulled the boy into the underworld of jaladoras, baby brokers who profited from stolen children. When López arrived at Larrad de Quan’s residence on June 9 with other adults and a young relative, Larrad de Quan’s accomplices emerged, methodically stabbing the adults to death while sparing only the child, whom they “immediately hid in a room...[for more] illegal business.” As night fell, Larrad de Quan and her accomplices wrapped the slaughtered bodies in bedsheets and loaded the corpses into the trunk and backseat of a blue Mitsubishi automobile before disposing of them at various locations around Guatemala City. No further information on the children’s whereabouts surfaced. Tragically, López’s ordeal was not an isolated incident. During the Guatemalan Civil War, sparked in part by the U.S.-backed coup of dem-

ocratically elected President Jacobo Árbenz due to perceived “Communist threats,” one in every one hundred Guatemalan children, primarily of Mayan descent, was adopted by international families, most notably in the United States, typically through illegal means. In an action arguably as chilling as the coercive adoptions themselves, the U.S. Embassy in Guatemala had knowledge of the fraudulent adoptions in the early 1980s, yet continued to issue visas to stolen children and refrained from formal intervention until the late 1990s, by which time Cold War objectives had waned. This deliberate passivity illustrates how, during the Cold War, the United States government, driven by a desire to “save” children from supposed Communist regimes, tolerated and enabled coercive adoptions in Guatemala.

Relying on interventionist strategies rooted in an exceptionalist worldview, U.S. foreign policy during the Cold War prioritized the containment of Communism. During the Cold War era, a period of geopolitical rivalry between the United States and the Soviet Union from 1947 to 1991, containment strategies rationalized direct intervention in countries where policymakers perceived Communist influence. For example, historian Greg Grandin has argued that “the 1954 overthrow of Jacobo Árbenz would not have occurred had it not been for the United States.” This coup, which unseated a democratically elected president committed to “the welfare of the people,” triggered decades of instability and human rights abuses in Guatemala. Amid this climate of anti-Communist zeal, ethical considerations were routinely subordinated to geopolitical imperatives, a pattern mirrored in the realm of coercive adoption. For instance, highly publicized “babylifts,” operations that aimed to bring orphans to safety and find them adoptive families in the United States and other countries, popularized the notion of adopting from overseas. U.S. couples, eager to adopt, lobbied Congress for laws that facilitated faster adoptions, arguing that this initiative would support Cold War objectives. Proponents contended that international adoption from war zones functioned as a form of repatriating U.S. soldiers’ offspring, effectively framing the process as the salvation of children from Communism rather than a violation of the birth mothers’ rights. Politically, “the mutual solution [between sending countries and the United States], found without consulting birth mothers, was adoption by white families in the [United States].” Such policies not only reflected U.S. cultural values but also underscored the extent to which Cold War ideology overrode ethical concerns. In the United States, the imperative to counter Communism reduced remarkably vulnerable lives to commodities.

The U.S.-backed coup that toppled Jacobo Árbenz in 1954 directly paved the way

for the Guatemalan genocide against the Indigenous Mayan population, making the U.S. government complicit in the ensuing atrocities. During the Guatemalan Civil War, the U.S. government “bolstered an intelligence system that...metastasized throughout the body politic.” By “push[ing] for the creation of a...counterinsurgency network [and] upgrading the intelligence system with new weapons,” the U.S. government demonstrated the prioritization of geopolitical interests over the ethical concerns of the Guatemalan Civil War. Supported by the United States, the Guatemalan army’s genocidal campaign against the Indigenous Maya included the abduction of children, who were forcibly taken from their villages and unlawfully placed for adoption. This practice extended U.S. complicity beyond military support and fell within the definition of genocide, as outlined in the 1948 Genocide Convention, which classified the act of “[f]orcibly transferring children of [one] group to another” as a punishable offense. Although the U.S. government justified its intervention as a necessary safeguard against Communism, this rationale concealed the devastating reality: U.S. aid enabled the systematic destruction of the Mayan population. This tacit endorsement of human rights violations implicitly allowed atrocities to unfold with impunity.

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Portraying international adoption as a means to uphold capitalist ideals and moral superiority over communist regimes, Cold War propaganda not only reinforced “traditional” family values but also influenced U.S. adoption policies. Throughout the 1950s, Cold War propaganda appeared in American media. Much of it “celebrated the distinct advantages of living in a prosperous, capitalist nation.” Cold War propaganda openly promoted “[t]he benefits of the nuclear family, positioning it as a moral safeguard against Communism.” International children, many of whom had living, loving parents, were transported to the United States to effectuate this perceived advancement.

Not only did U.S. policymakers tolerate coercive adoptions from Guatemala, but they also actively defended them. The Reagan administration’s view that the ideological struggle against Communism (See Figure 1) justified human rights abuses evolved to deflecting reports of fraudulent adoption practices and attributing false rumors to Communist propaganda. As tensions heightened with the strengthening of leftist movements in Latin America, U.S. officials treated the removal of Guatemalan children as a humanitarian intervention meant to protect them from the influence of Communist regimes. Moreover, authorities viewed Guatemala as a critical battleground in the global fight against Soviet expansion. As a corollary, ideological framing extended beyond military aid and intelligence networks, seeping into adoption practices that transformed vulnerable children into

ideological assets. Reinforcing the urgency to act against leftist regimes, President Reagan and “most of his key advisors believed that conflicts in Latin America” sprang from a “grand design” by the Soviet Union to expand its global reach. This perspective underpinned the Reagan Doctrine, which aimed to “weaken the links between radical Third World regimes and the Soviet Union” and promote U.S. interests by undermining leftist governments. As Reagan’s ambassador to the United Nations, Jeane Kirkpatrick, asserted, “Central America is the most important place in the world for the United States.” Upon taking office, Reagan quickly moved to convert Latin America into a zone where “U.S. power would stand as an unquestioned bulwark against the Left,” even if such actions relied on violations of fundamental human rights. Despite evidence of human rights violations and coercive practices, U.S. officials sanitized the moral implications of these adoptions, effectively downplaying, if not ignoring, the exploitation at the heart of these adoptions. Children, once deemed “emotionally priceless,” became transactional assets in a system where demand dictated their value, paving the way for a thriving transnational adoption market.

In the 1970s, a shortage of adoptable infants in the United States, coupled with the displacement of children during the Guatemalan Civil War, created a perfect opportunity for a market-driven exchange between sender and receiver. For those who wished to adopt in the United States during this time, a so-called “white baby famine” emerged, fueled by declining birth rates, the legalization of abortion, the increased use of contraceptives, and shifting cultural norms around family structure, including but not limited to greater acceptance of single parenting and delayed timelines for marriage and childbirth. Consequently, North American families increasingly sought to adopt Guatemalan infants. For instance, in 1979, a U.S. adoption agency sent a letter to the Elisa Martínez Orphanage in Guatemala stating that “the adoption of an infant in the U.S. is very difficult due to a lack of available children.” In response to increasing demand, *jaladoras*—a term meaning “baby pullers,” derived from the Spanish verb *jalar* (“to pull”)—found new incentives to operate.

The rise of international adoptions in Guatemala gradually eclipsed domestic adoptions, allowing intermediaries and private agencies to dictate adoption decisions and prioritize profit over child welfare. On February 4, 1976, a devastating 7.5-magnitude earthquake struck Guatemala, shaking the country for forty-five seconds. As a result, “[t]housands of children [were] orphaned,” prompting the Guatemalan government to declare an orphan crisis. The aftermath of this natural disaster led the Guatemalan government to establish a privatized process for international adoptions. This process benefited intermediaries while reducing government accountability and allowed unethical practices

to thrive under the guise of addressing a humanitarian crisis. By legalizing “fully privatized adoptions” in 1977, the Guatemalan government created an environment where lawyers and *jaladoras* could collaborate without governmental oversight. This privatized process rapidly supplanted the state adoption system. Adoptive parents in the United States tended to favor the private system because it was “faster, and because lawyers were free to look for exactly the kind of child they wished to adopt.” By implication, the growing popularity of private adoptions demonstrated how legal changes in Guatemala enabled the commodification of children, turning them into products to be selected based on specific criteria. Furthermore, children placed for adoption through the private system, unlike those in state-run orphanages, were “very rarely orphans” because “[o]rphans were not an attractive proposition for lawyers.” A birth mother could consent to adoption by signing relinquishment papers, often without fully understanding the implications, whereas adopting an orphan required a judge’s declaration of abandonment, a significantly longer process. This privatized system created opportunities for *jaladoras* to exploit loopholes and meet the rising international demand by strategically manipulating the legal distinctions between forcibly relinquished children and true orphans.

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Leveraging their proximity to vulnerable communities, *jaladoras* manipulated defenseless families to secure children for private adoption lawyers, transforming their insider status into a lucrative advantage. This dynamic created a system where poverty and desperation enabled the recruitment of *jaladoras*, whose actions ultimately sustained a cycle of exploitation that enriched foreign adoption networks. A common tactic *jaladoras* used involved convincing mothers to relinquish their children under the guise of securing a better future. While some *jaladoras* resorted to outright child abduction, most relied on persuasion, targeting young mothers and pregnant women in public places like buses and markets. Once a *jaladora* chose a victim, “[t]hey would flip through photo albums showing Guatemalan boys and girls in the comfortable homes of middle-class families” in the United States, presenting an alluring narrative that masked the harsh realities of forced adoptions. Another particularly cruel tactic *jaladoras* employed involved offering fake scholarships to the children of illiterate mothers. Deceived into believing they were securing a better future for their children, mothers unknowingly signed adoption consent forms, allowing their fraudulently obtained children to disappear from Guatemala forever. Furthermore, *jaladoras* committed physically violent and heinous acts if mothers refused to comply. Bruce Harris, an international adoption monitor, found “many documented cases of mothers...who were drugged and given a [forced] caesarean section.” The violence in-

flicted upon these women underscored the lengths to which jaladoras would go to profit from the illicit adoption trade. This incredibly disturbing abuse set the stage for countless personal tragedies.

Personal stories of mothers and children caught in the web of coercive adoptions highlight the devastating human impact of the systematic exploitation orchestrated by jaladoras and facilitated by U.S. adoption practices. In 1972, an adoptive mother contacted the private orphanage from which she obtained her Guatemalan daughter, questioning why her little girl had been placed for adoption. A social worker from the program wrote her back, instructing her to tell her daughter that the biological “mother died when she was very young.” However, the biological mother was not dead at all; in fact, an internal record that the adoptive mother never saw stated that “[t]he [biological] mother presented herself to reclaim the minor.” This case exemplified the deception and deliberate misinformation used to manipulate adoptive parents and justify child placements. This story, however, was just one facet of the broader reality, where the exploitation of children often escalated into more violent and forceful methods. Elivia Ramírez Cano was thirty-two years old when she was deceived and kidnapped by a Guatemalan couple promising her a job in their home. Instead of working, she was held captive in the couple’s house until she was ready to give birth. She shared her traumatic experience, lamenting, “I was given drugs to make the birth quicker, and then the baby was pulled out of my stomach...I didn’t know whether it was a boy or a girl...the couple told me I was too poor to be a mother and they were going to put my baby up for adoption.” The couple’s justification for their horrendous actions reinforced the harmful narrative in international adoption, in which financial privilege was assumed to always equate to a “better life.” The kidnappers’ cruelty mirrors the ruthless deception encountered by Mariela Sifontes’s mother, Lorena. Sifontes was born in Roosevelt Hospital in Guatemala City, and, after two days, they told young Lorena that Mariela had been taken to another hospital. When Lorena went to the other hospital, looking for her daughter, hospital employees told her that she could not see her baby because her daughter had “died [and]...[had been] buried in a mass grave.” In reality, Mariela was being held captive in a basement until her illegal adoption was completed. Upon learning about and mentally processing her coercive adoption, Mariela, despite having a “very good childhood,” began to suffer from post-traumatic stress disorder. Like Mariela, Osmin Tobar endured the forced adoption system in 1997. His adoption, organized by the jaladora Susana Loarca, who was arrested multiple times throughout the early 2000s, caused him to repeatedly relive the memory of being “taken from his mother in Guatemala like a bro-

ken record.” Moreover, an image of Loarca with stolen babies in Guatemala (See Figure 3) underscores the trauma and corruption entrenched in these coercive adoptions. Tobar, at the age of seven, was allegedly ripped away from his biological family because authorities “received reports that he had been abused and abandoned by his mother.” Authorities neglected to investigate these allegations. Tobar’s father, who was separated from his mother, also contested the declaration of abandonment that allowed his son’s international adoption “without [his] consent,” evidence of the systemic disregard for paternal authority in coercive adoption practices. After learning of the coercive nature of his adoption, Tobar undertook the emotional process of seeking justice before the Inter-American Court of Human Rights (See Figures 4 and 5), where he exposed Guatemala’s systemic failures. These cases revealed a disturbing pattern in which coercive adoptions thrived not only through deception and force but also through the complicity of institutions, including the U.S. Embassy, which ignored red flags and failed to protect biological families, continuing to issue visas to stolen children while allowing these practices to persist unchecked.

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The U.S. Embassy’s failure to intervene in adoption fraud showed a calculated prioritization of American adoptive parents’ desires over the protection of Guatemalan families. Despite internal concerns about kidnapping-for-adoption scandals, embassy officials worried more about a “possible public relations disaster” than the human cost of coerced adoptions. A 1988 cable from Secretary of State George Shultz acknowledged that “[m]any adopting parents have invested a tremendous amount of time and suffered emotional strain,” suggesting that adoptive parents’ emotional commitment made them “prime candidates for exploitation.” However, nowhere did these memos express concern for the emotional trauma endured by birth mothers and children who were forcibly separated. The embassy’s internal communications consistently emphasized minimizing delays in adoption processing to appease politically influential adoptive parents. One 1989 cable starkly captured this imbalance, stating that embassy officials often found themselves “caught between anxious prospective U.S. parents and an unreliable... fraudulent Guatemalan adoption system.” This disparity translated into a system where the urgency of American desires overrode ethical considerations, allowing the fraudulent adoptions to persist. Even when evidence of falsified adoption paperwork, such as fake birth certificates, surfaced in 1988, the embassy imposed no significant controls on adoption practices until a decade later, when mandatory DNA testing began.

One might argue that adoption procedures ought to be simplified to prioritize the child’s economic well-being, as financially stable U.S. households are often perceived as

offering a better future than poverty-stricken Guatemala. Yet, many of the commentators who have argued that coercive adoptions caused no harm happen to have participated in the illegal adoption industry. For example, in 2006, the jaladora Susana Luarca asked New York Times officials: “[w]hich would a child prefer, to grow up in misery or to go to the U.S., where there is everything?” Similarly, Edmond Mulet, a former Guatemalan diplomat at the United Nations and a recent political candidate in Guatemalan elections who was found guilty in 1991 of falsifying adoption papers, remarked that “children’s lives were saved by those adoptions, there are no victims here.” Likewise, in an interview with the Guatemalan newspaper company Siglo Vientiuno, Guatemalan lawyer Linares Beltranena argued that “[i]f we restrict the adoption of children, those who are going to suffer are the children.” By reducing children to objects of exchange, Beltranena’s position reflected how simplifying adoption processes prioritized financial status over ethics. As Ramón Cadena Rámila lamented in his UNICEF report on the trafficking of Guatemalan children, “children are treated as objects of commerce and not as subjects of the law.” Mulet, Luarca, and Beltranena’s narratives, which frame coercive adoptions as acts of salvation, parallel the views of American adopters who advocated for simplifying the adoption process without acknowledging the potential for exploitation. Laura Ingraham, a controversial conservative television personality who adopted three children, including one from Guatemala, reflected on the lengthy process of acquiring her Guatemalan daughter. She argued that adoption should be made easier for American couples, emphasizing the benefits for both the children and the adoptive parents. While Ingraham’s viewpoint highlighted the desire to simplify the adoption process, her perspective overlooked the complexities involved in ensuring ethical adoptions. Moreover, Ingraham’s sentiment overlooked the perspectives of Indigenous communities. For example, in 2010, reflecting on the aftermath of the coercive adoptions, the U.S. Embassy in Guatemala acknowledged that certain Indigenous groups had raised apprehensions, with one cable declaring that, “[s]ome persons... complained that the more developed countries were stealing their heritage and future by adopting their children.”

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Altogether, the coercive adoptions that flourished in Guatemala reflected a disturbing convergence of U.S. foreign policy, Cold War ideology, and market-driven exploitation that commodified vulnerable children. In prioritizing geopolitical interests and promoting capitalist ideals, the U.S. government tolerated a system that transformed adoption into an industry where profit overshadowed ethics. Jaladoras exploited impoverished families under the guise of securing better futures, while U.S government author-

ities ignored mounting evidence of fraud in order to appease adoptive parents. This negligence, combined with Cold War propaganda that framed international adoption as a moral rescue mission, legitimized the trafficking of Guatemalan children. Even after mandating DNA testing and birth mother interviews to prevent fraud, these new measures failed due to weak oversight and pervasive corruption. Personal stories of mothers robbed of their children and adoptees suffering lifelong trauma underscored the devastating human cost of this exploitation. While proponents justified these adoptions as acts of salvation, they disregarded the voices of biological families whose suffering was deemed irrelevant. The closure of international adoptions from Guatemala in 2007 came too late to undo the harm inflicted on thousands of families, serving as a stark reminder that prioritizing political and economic objectives over ethical considerations leaves a lasting legacy of injustice.

Figure 1: McCormick et al., *Policy Roundtable*, 1.

Figure Description: Former President Ronald Reagan holding up a shirt that reads "Stop Communism [in] Central America" as he departs the White House for Camp David in 1986.



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Figure 2: Washington, "Children for Sale."



Figure Description: Childcare workers with children waiting for adoption in Guatemala.



Figure 3: *Susana Luarca.*

<https://www.soy502.com/articulo/capturan-tres-en-la-costa-sur-por-adopciones-ilegales>.

Figure Description: Susana Luarca in a private adoption facility where she facilitated irregular adoptions.

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Figura 4: Sifontes, "Niños robados."

Figure Description: Osmin Tobar, who was abducted and brought to the United States as a child, brought his case before the Inter-American Court of Human Rights in 2018, which ruled in his favor.

Figure 5: Abbott, "Guatemalan Government,"



Figure Description: In July 2024, Guatemalan President Bernardo Arévalo embraced Flor de María Ramírez, the biological mother of Osmin Tobar.

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